

Computers are everywhere

Some people feel computers are too complex for them to use without special skills and knowledge. However, they interact with computers all the time without necessarily realizing it.

Look closely

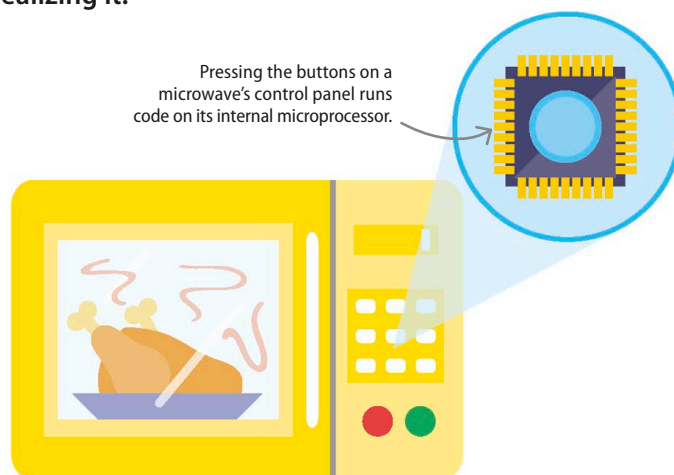
Computers are almost everywhere, not just in the conventional setup that includes a monitor, keyboard, and mouse. They are also found in everyday devices such as mobile phones, lifts, televisions, and cars. From watching movies to playing games, and even making dinner, computers can be used to do almost anything.

▷ Household devices

Many household devices contain computers. Selecting a program on a microwave, for example, actually runs a small program on the computer embedded in the device.

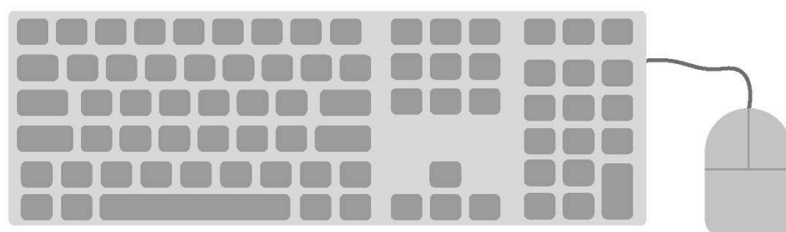
SEE ALSO

Computing for you	16–17 >
Inside a computer	34–35 >
Peripheral devices	36–37 >
The computer chip	38–39 >
What is hardware?	48–49 >
Smartphones and tablets	52–53 >



Hardware and software

The physical parts of a computer are called hardware. These include things we can see, such as the monitor and computer case, as well as things we can't see, such as the motherboard and microprocessor inside the computer case. Things like programs, the operating system, and firmware (a type of program that is embedded into the microprocessor) are called software. They allow users to access the capabilities of the hardware.



△ Input devices

There are a lot of ways to input information and interact with software running on a computer. The most common ways to do this are by using a keyboard, a mouse, or a touchscreen.

